

Topic 9: Output Formatting and Control

9.1 Requesting Structured Output

- Always state the format explicitly -- models default to prose unless told otherwise
- Common formats: JSON, Markdown, CSV, numbered list, bullet list, table, XML
- For JSON: specify the exact schema with field names and types
- Add 'Return only the [format], no explanation or preamble' to suppress extra text
- Validate programmatically -- even with clear instructions, models occasionally deviate

```
Extract the following from the email below.  
Return a JSON object with exactly these fields:  
{  
  sender_name: string,  
  sender_email: string,  
  meeting_date: string (YYYY-MM-DD or null),  
  action_items: array of strings,  
  urgency: 'Low' | 'Medium' | 'High'  
}  
Return ONLY the JSON. No markdown fences, no explanation.  
  
Email: [email text here]
```

9.2 Controlling Length

- Specify length in words, sentences, paragraphs, or tokens: 'in exactly 3 sentences', 'under 100 words'
- For bullet lists: 'Provide exactly 5 bullet points'
- Models tend to over-explain -- add 'Be concise. Do not repeat information.' to reduce verbosity
- For very short outputs: 'Answer in one word: Yes or No'

9.3 Controlling Tone and Style

- Tone descriptors: formal, casual, professional, empathetic, authoritative, humorous, neutral
- Reading level: 'Explain at a Grade 6 reading level', 'Write for a PhD audience'
- Style matching: 'Match the tone of the example below:', then provide a writing sample
- Brand voice: describe key adjectives (e.g., 'bold, approachable, direct, never corporate-sounding')

9.4 Handling Uncertainty

- Instruct the model to express uncertainty rather than hallucinate: 'If you are not certain, say so explicitly'
- Ask for confidence levels: 'Rate your confidence in this answer from 1-5'
- Add: 'If the answer is not found in the provided text, reply: Information not available'
- For factual tasks: 'Only use information from the provided context. Do not use outside knowledge.'

Answer the question using ONLY the information in the context below.

If the answer is not in the context, respond with:

'I could not find this information in the provided context.'

Do not guess or use outside knowledge.

Context: [document text here]

Question: What was the company's revenue in Q3 2024?